Tidewatch Backup Agent: Operations Runbook

This runbook describes how to install, configure and troubleshoot the Tidewatch backup agent on Linux servers. It is written for the on-call engineers of the platform team.

1. Installation

Prerequisites

- A 64-bit Linux host with systemd 245 or later
- At least 2 GB of free disk space for the local cache
- Outbound HTTPS access to the backup endpoint

Install the agent with the bootstrap script and check that the service has started.

```
$ curl -fsSL https://example.org/tidewatch/install.sh | sh
$ sudo systemctl enable --now tidewatch
$ tidewatch status
```

2. Configuration

The agent reads its settings from /etc/tidewatch/agent.yaml. A minimal file looks like this.

```
agent:
  name: edge-backup-01
  interval: 15m
targets:
  - path: /var/lib/app/data
    exclude: ["*.tmp", "cache/"]
retention:
  daily: 7
  weekly: 4
  monthly: 12
```

Key	Type	Default	Description
agent.interval	duration	30m	Time between two backup runs
targets[].path	string	none	Directory to protect; required
targets[].exclude	list	[]	Glob patterns that are skipped
retention.daily	integer	7	Number of daily snapshots kept

Retention policy

Snapshots are pruned after every successful run. To change the policy, follow these steps.

1. Edit the retention block in the configuration file.
2. Validate and reload the agent:
    a. Run tidewatch config check and read the output.
    b. Run sudo systemctl reload tidewatch.
3. Confirm the new schedule with tidewatch status.

3. Troubleshooting

Every failed run writes one structured line to the journal. A typical entry is shown below.

```
{"ts":"2026-05-02T02:15:09Z","level":"error","code":"E214",
 "target":"/var/lib/app/data","msg":"upload timed out after 120s"}
```

Code	Meaning	First action
E101	Configuration file could not be parsed	Run tidewatch config check
E214	Upload timed out	Check network route and proxy settings
E307	Target directory is not readable	Fix permissions for the tidewatch user
E412	Cache volume is full	Free space or raise the cache limit

Escalation

If two consecutive runs fail with the same code, escalate in this order.

– Page the platform on-call engineer.
– Open an incident ticket and attach the last 200 journal lines.
– Inform the data owner if the gap exceeds 24 hours.

4. Support

Questions about this runbook can be sent to the platform team mailbox. Please include the agent version printed by the status command.

```
$ tidewatch version
tidewatch 2.8.1 (build 4f9c2d1)
```